



edges of the bat. He has opened the bowling in 50 innings in Test cricket, snapping up 165 wickets at an average of 19.36, reaffirming his efficacy as a new-ball bowler.

Ashwin has brought a unique flair to cricket. His clever run-outs, and tactical retirements showcase his innovative approach to the ever-changing game. He has shown time and again that the beauty of his craft is its reward. The 10 Player-of-the-Series awards, one shy of Muttiah Muralitharan's record 11, attest to it.

It is easy to go overboard here and get drunk on superlatives while talking about athletes like Ashwin. Just as it is also easy to become inured by repetition to the pitch of Ashwin's brilliance, there has always been a sense of that little something in Ashwin's talent that never reached

its end point.

It is conceivable that Ashwin himself shares this sentiment, as evident in his unwavering resolve. Rather than sulking over defeat, he appears to use setbacks as opportunities to regroup and press forward.

Beyond the mere act of delivering overs, Ashwin engages in a contest with his opponents, inviting them to a closely contested battle of wits, seeking to establish dominance in his sporting domain.

Ashwin also has five Test hundreds to his name, the last of which came against England in Chennai in 2021. That innings made him the first all-rounder since Garry Sobers at Headingley in 1966 to take five wickets and score a century against England.

Coming back to Rajkot, at the

All-round ability: Ashwin also has five Test hundreds to his name, the last of which came against England in Chennai in 2021. VIJAY SONEJI

close of play on Day 2, he said: "It has been quite a long journey. Firstly, I'd like to dedicate the final wicket to my father. He's been through the thick and thin of everything I've done in my life. He's been a constant support for me." But then to business. "Five hundred wickets are done and dusted now; we've got a game hanging in the balance."

Just a few hours later, the BCCI announced Ashwin had withdrawn from the Test because of a family emergency. He would later return to bowl India to a 2-1 series lead on the fourth day, securing his place among the game's royalty.